brought to 10 Janpath. A press conference was quickly organised, where the young man's injuries, including the loss of vision in one eye, became the basis for Rahul to directly attack Shah and demand his resignation. He later led a sit-in at Parliament Street police station until the police finally relented and agreed to register an FIR in the case against "unknown persons".

Just weeks earlier, Rahul had displayed a similar instinct for political theatre when he proposed that Congress leaders march to the prime minister's residence to protest the NEET paper leaks. Only his sister and party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi and general secretary organisation K.C. Venugopal were initially in the know. The rest of the Congress leadership was summoned to party president Mallikarjun Kharge's residence, ostensibly to celebrate his birthday, before being told that the real destination lay barely a kilometre away.

RAHUL HAS PUSHED THE CONGRESS FROM ITS CENTRIST INSTINCTS TOWARDS A MORE EXPLICIT CENTRE-LEFT POSITION ON SOCIAL JUSTICE AND ECONOMIC POWER...HE IS NOW LESS AN ELECTION MANAGER, MORE THE PARTY'S PRINCIPAL IDEOLOGUE

In fact, Rahul's focus on the youth and the problems in the education sector began much before the arrival of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP). For years, he has spoken about exam leaks, recruitment delays and the shrinking opportunities for educated youth. Chhatron ki Goonj was launched in Kota on June 17, three days before CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke began his mobilisation at Jantar Mantar on June 20.

Yet the rise of the CJP exposed the difference between identifying a grievance and politically owning it. The August 2026 INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation survey highlighted this very contradiction. Between January and August, Modi's score as the preferred prime minister fell nearly six points to 48.7 per cent. But it didn't reflect in Rahul's ratings—which barely moved, from 26.6 to 27.1 per cent. The gap narrowed because Modi lost support, not because Rahul harvested it. The chasm gets wider among the young, the constituency Rahul has consciously pursued. Among Gen Z respondents, Modi's ratings fell to 43.9 per cent, but Rahul's stood at 27.4 per cent, similar to his overall score.

The numbers are significant because Rahul has spent years trying to occupy precisely this space. His formal involvement with youth politics goes back to 2007, when he was given charge of the Youth Congress. His politics then moved through several identities, from the UPA-era rebel prince to temple visits and 'soft Hindutva', and the unsuccessful '*UP ke ladke* (UP's lads)' experiment with Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav in 2017.

And that exactly captures both Rahul's evolution and his present dilemma. After more than two decades in public life, he is clearly more comfortable in his political skin and more consequential nationally than at any previous point in his career. The politician once caricatured as an entitled dynast is now the first formally recognised Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha in a decade. Rahul has pushed the Congress from its older centrist instincts towards a more explicit centre-left position on social justice and economic power. Indeed, he is now less an election manager and more the Congress's principal ideologue. Yet he increasingly resembles a lone ranger, constructing a political argument that the wider Opposition, and often even his own Congress, is unable to carry through to the last mile.

BATTLE LINES

The issues Rahul Gandhi has repeatedly put on the national agenda since 2024

- **ECONOMY:** Jobs, unemployment, migration, manufacturing, Make in India, MSMEs and the GST burden
- **EDUCATION:** NEET aberrations, question paper leaks, recruitment irregularities, student anger, higher education, Sangh Parivar's ideological control
- **REPRESENTATION:** Caste census, OBC and minority quotas, the 50 per cent quota ceiling in reservations, lateral entry in government posts
- **AGRICULTURE:** Legal guarantee for MSP, tariffs, trade deals and protection of farm interests
- **ELECTIONS:** SIR, electoral roll integrity, voter exclusion, vote *chori* and Election Commission neutrality

THE RESONANCE CURVE

In Rahul's defence, party general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala feels the timing is right, pointing to a shift in the terrain that sustained the BJP after 2014. Religious and caste polarisation, he argues, is increasingly colliding with such factors as unemployment, shrinking opportunities and anxieties about the future that cut across class and caste. "Rahul read this situation much earlier, and he has been saying it consistently. People now see a sincerity of purpose, are hearing things that relate directly to their lives. That is why he is resonating more today," says Surjewala.

Most experts who acknowledge Rahul's rise attach an important qualifica-